

RISC-V

Introduction

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RISC-V

RISC-V is an open standard Instruction Set Architecture (ISA), having few instructions in 3 different versions: 32, 64, and 128 bits.

The RISC-V ISA is defined as a base integer ISA plus extensions and user customizations.

In the original name, V states for 5, variations and vectors.

The main interest is due to a common free and open standard to which software can be ported and running on any developed RISC-V hardware.



RISC-V (II)

History:

- In May 2010 was proposed as part of the Parallel Computing Laboratory (Par Lab) at UC Berkeley, leaded by Prof. David Patterson
- RISC-V (fifth version of the ISA), then V means the roman number, but also the possibility to add new variants and vector instructions
- In January 2015, the first RISC-V Workshop was held, and the RISC-V Foundation started with 36 Founding Members



RISC-V (III)

History:

- In November 2018, the RISC-V Foundation announced a joint collaboration with the Linux Foundation.
- In 2026, the RISC-V foundation counts with more than 300 members including a wide range of companies, academic institutions.
- The number of individuals is larger than 4,500.
- Polito is not yet a member.



RISC-V Generalities

- Freely licensed open standard
- Load-store architecture
- Fixed 32-bit instruction set
- Additional ISA extensions, for example for security, floating point, and vector operations
- Addressing modes:
 - Displacement
 - Immediate
 - Register indirect

RISC-V Generalities (II)

Data types:

- **Byte (8 bits)**
- **Half Words (16 bits)**
- **Words (32 bits)**
- **Double Words (64 bits)**
- **32-bit single precision floating-point**
- **64-bit double precision floating-point.**

Relative (+-) number representation: two's complement

Given a binary number A of N bits, two's complement (2C) can be defined as :

$$\overline{\overline{A}} = 2^N - A = \overline{A} + 1$$

Using a 3-bit representation :

$$+ 3_{10} \rightarrow 011_{2C}$$

$$- 1_{10} \rightarrow 111_{2C}$$

$$000_{2C} \rightarrow + 0_{10}$$

$$100_{2C} \rightarrow - 4_{10}$$

Binary	Decimal
000	0
001	1
010	2
011	3
100	-4
101	-3
110	-2
111	-1

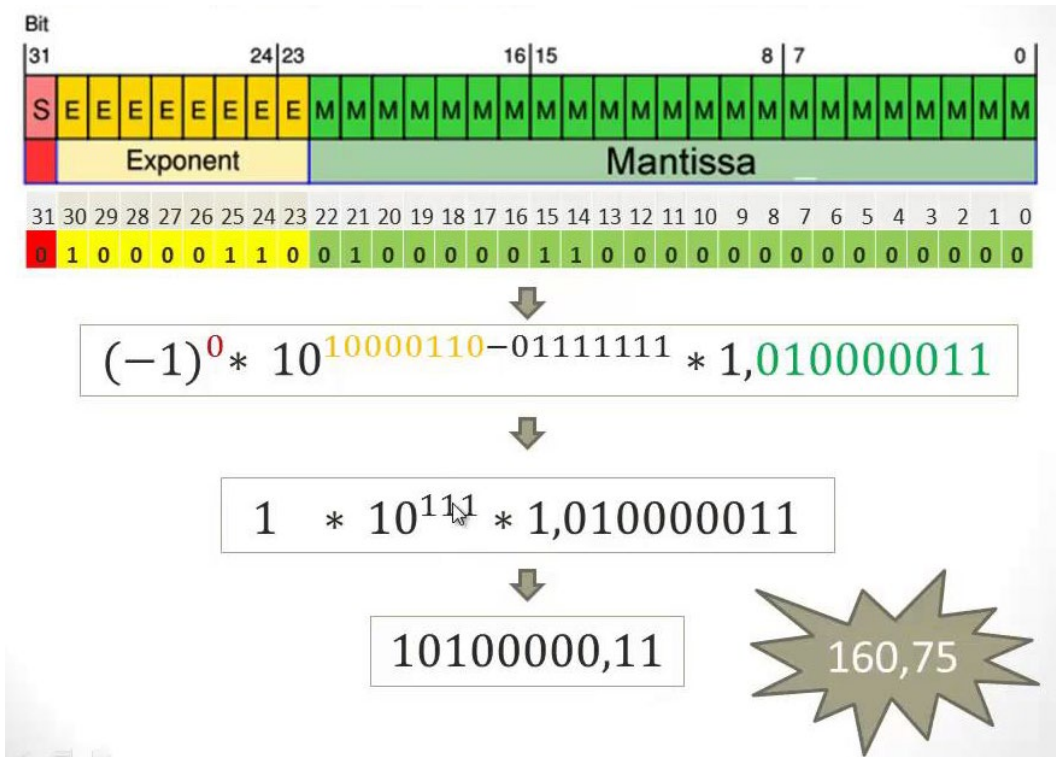
IEEE 754 32-bit representation

The IEEE 754 representation is composed by:

Sign: 1 bit

Exponent: 8 bits

Mantissa: 23 bits.



Instruction length encoding

RISC-V allows a variable encoding in multiples of 16-bit blocks if code size reduction or specific implementations are needed.

- **Fixed-length 32-bit instructions for the base versions**
 - **32-bit instructions have their lowest two bits set to 11**
 - **16-bit instructions may have their lowest two bits equal to 00, 01, or 10**
- **In the case of 32-bit instructions, code memory alignment is a constraint, in other cases, the alignment is relaxed**
- **Little-endian memory system.**

RISC-V Instruction set organization

It counts with three base instructions sets plus a variety of optional extensions.

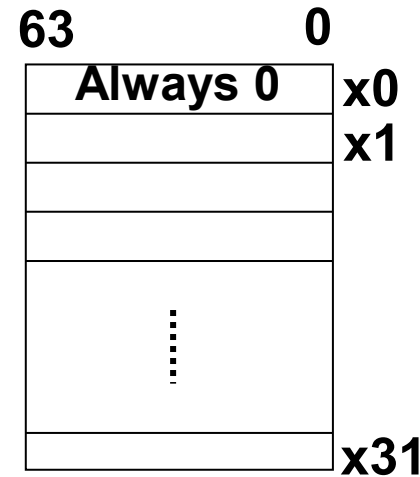
- For example, a 64-bit RISC-V possible ISA is defined as RV64IMAFD, known as RV64G: general-purpose scalar instruction set.
- The 32-bit version is called RV32G.

Name of base or extension	Functionality
RV32I	Base 32-bit integer instruction set with 32 registers
RV32E	Base 32-bit instruction set but with only 16 registers; intended for very low-end embedded applications
RV64I	Base 64-bit instruction set; all registers are 64-bits, and instructions to move 64-bit from/to the registers (LD and SD) are added
M	Adds integer multiply and divide instructions
A	Adds atomic instructions needed for concurrent processing; see Chapter 5
F	Adds single precision (32-bit) IEEE floating point, includes 32 32-bit floating point registers, instructions to load and store those registers and operate on them
D	Extends floating point to double precision, 64-bit, making the registers 64-bits, adding instructions to load, store, and operate on the registers
Q	Further extends floating point to add support for quad precision, adding 128-bit operations
L	Adds support for 64- and 128-bit decimal floating point for the IEEE standard
C	Defines a compressed version of the instruction set intended for small-memory-sized embedded applications. Defines 16-bit versions of common RV32I instructions
V	A future extension to support vector operations (see Chapter 4)
B	A future extension to support operations on bit fields
T	A future extension to support transactional memory
P	An extension to support packed SIMD instructions: see Chapter 4
RV128I	A future base instruction set providing a 128-bit address space

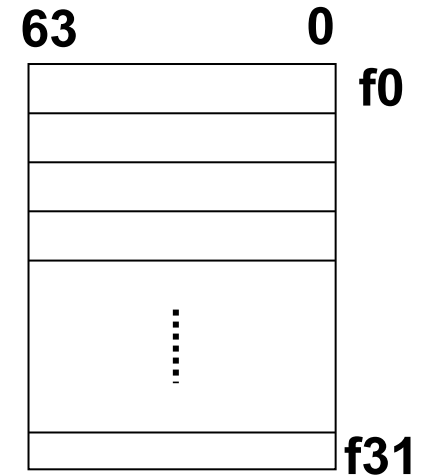
RISC-V registers

RV64G register bank:

- Register bank or register file of 32 elements
- 32 Integer registers
 - x0, x1, x2... x31
 - x0 is hardwired to 0.
- Floating point single (32-bit) and/or double precision (64-bit).



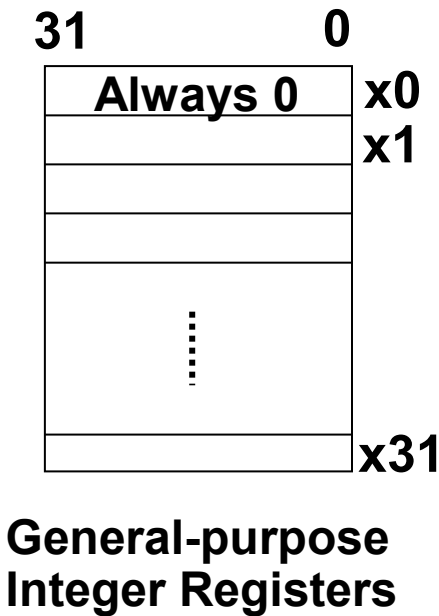
General-purpose
Integer Registers



Floating-point
Registers (FPRs)

RISC-V registers for 32-bit version

RV32I register bank:



Register	ABI Name	Description	Register	ABI Name	Description
x0	zero	hardwired zero	x16	a6	function argument 6
x1	ra	return address	x17	a7	function argument 7
x2	sp	stack pointer	x18	s2	saved register 2
x3	gp	global pointer	x19	s3	saved register 3
x4	tp	thread pointer	x20	s4	saved register 4
x5	t0	temporary register 0	x21	s5	saved register 5
x6	t1	temporary register 1	x22	s6	saved register 6
x7	t2	temporary register 2	x23	s7	saved register 7
x8	s0 / fp	saved register 0 / frame pointer	x24	s8	saved register 8
x9	s1	saved register 1	x25	s9	saved register 9
x10	a0	function argument 0 / return value 0	x26	s10	saved register 10
x11	a1	function argument 1 / return value 1	x27	s11	saved register 11
x12	a2	function argument 2	x28	t3	temporary register 3
x13	a3	function argument 3	x29	t4	temporary register 4
x14	a4	function argument 4	x30	t5	temporary register 5
x15	a5	function argument 5	x31	t6	temporary register 6



ABI: Application Binary Interface

Addressing Modes

Addressing modes for data transfers are Immediate and Displacement, both counting with an encoded field of 12 bits.

Immediate Addressing Mode

- `addi x1, x2, 32`

$$x1 \leftarrow x2 + 32$$

- `addi x1, x0, 32`

$$x1 \leftarrow 32$$

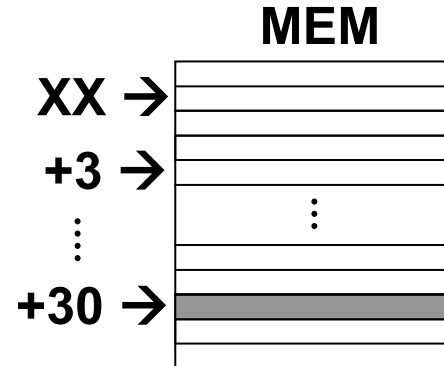
Addressing Modes

Displacement

- `lw x1, 30(x2)`

`x2 = XX`

`x1 ← MEM[x2 + 30]`



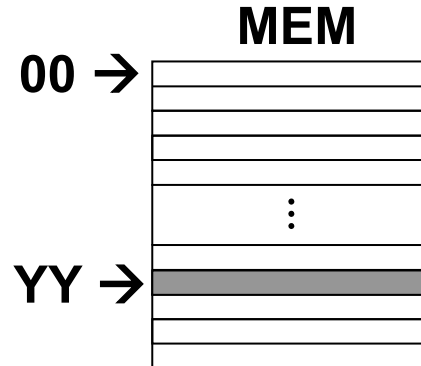
Addressing Modes

Displacement – Register indirect

- **lw x1, 0(x2) → *Register Indirect***

x2 = YY

x1 ← MEM[x2]

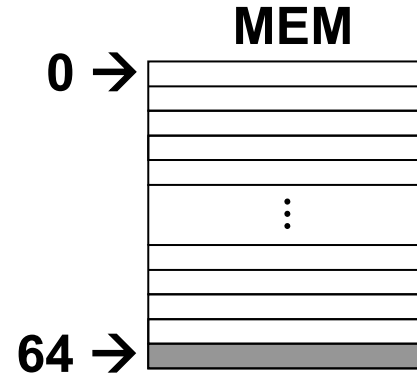


Addressing Modes

Displacement – Absolute Addressing

- `lw x1, 64(x0)` → *Absolute Addressing*

`x1 ← MEM[64]`



Instruction Format

A CPU instruction is a single 32-bit aligned word, that may include:

- a 7-bit primary opcode
- a 12-bit field for displacement addressing, immediate or PC relative branches.

The CPU instruction formats are:

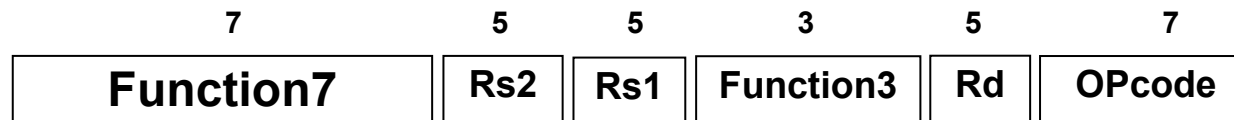
- Register: R-type
- Immediate: I-Type
- Store: S-Type
- Branch: B-Type
- Jump: U-Type
- Jump: J-Type

31	30	25	24	21	20	19	15	14	12	11	8	7	6	0	
funct7				rs2		rs1	funct3		rd			opcode		R-type	
imm[11:0]						rs1	funct3		rd			opcode		I-type	
imm[11:5]				rs2		rs1	funct3		imm[4:0]			opcode		S-type	
imm[12]	imm[10:5]			rs2		rs1	funct3		imm[4:1]	imm[11]	opcode		B-type		
imm[31:12]									rd			opcode		U-type	
imm[20]	imm[10:1]			imm[11]		imm[19:12]			rd			opcode		J-type	

Instruction Format – Register

R-Type instructions

Register – Register operations.

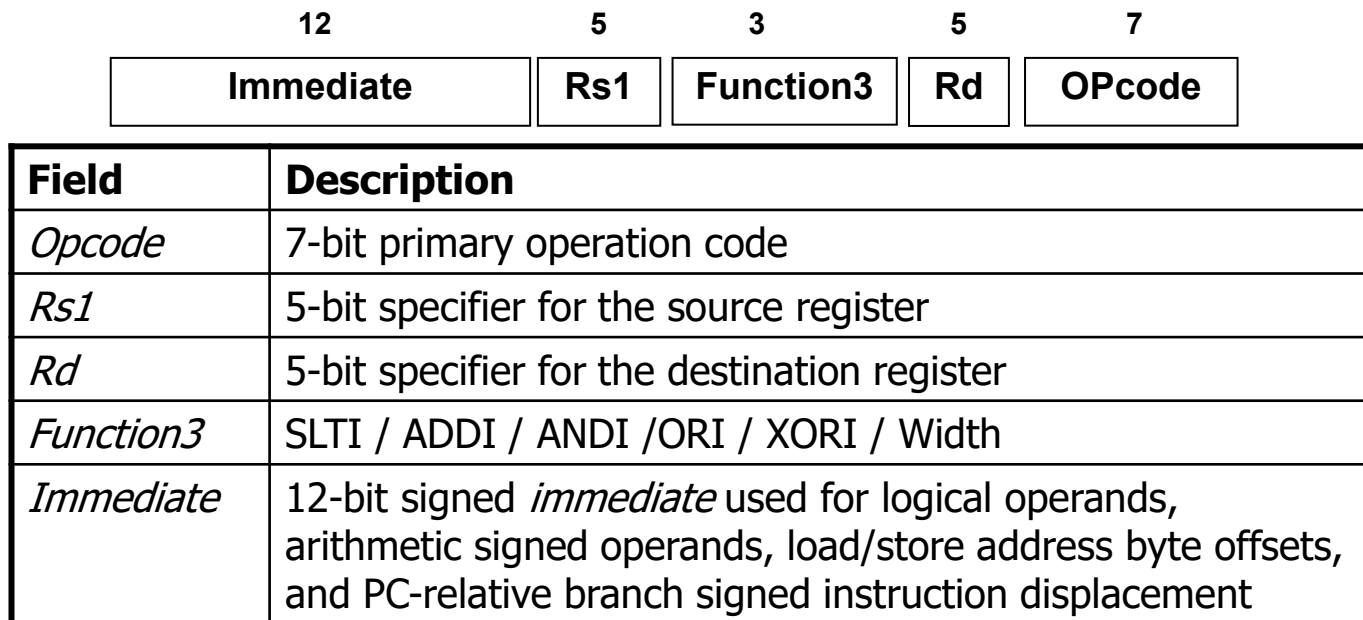


Field	Description
<i>Opcode</i>	7-bit primary operation code
<i>Rs1 – Rs2</i>	5-bit specifier for the source registers
<i>Rd</i>	5-bit specifier for the destination register
<i>Function3</i>	SLTI / ADDI / ANDI / ORI / XORI / SUB / SRA
<i>Function7</i>	Help on selecting the specific type of operation

Instruction Format – Immediate

I-Type instructions

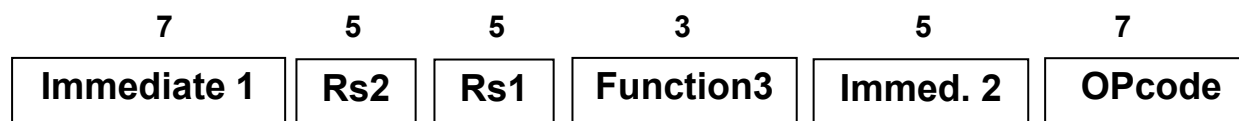
Immediate value is loaded with a sign extension if required.



Instruction Format – Store

S-Type instructions

Store, compare and branch instructions.



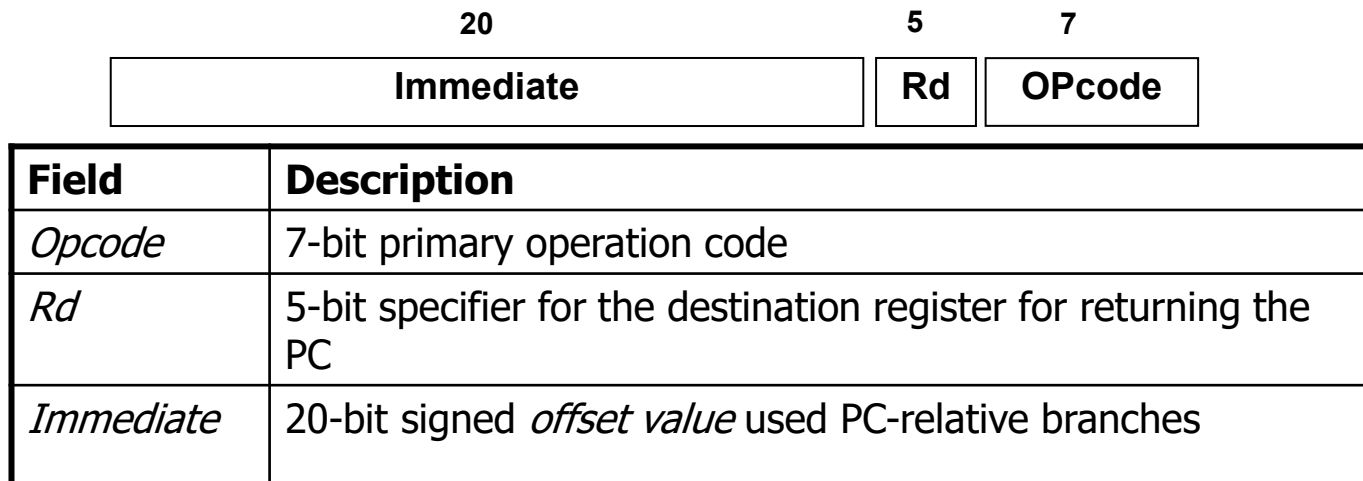
Field	Description
<i>Opcode</i>	STORE
<i>Rs2</i>	5-bit specifier for the source register to copy in memory
<i>Rs1</i>	5-bit specifier for the register to add to the sign extended 12-bits immediate value [Imm1][Imm2]
<i>Function3</i>	SLTI / ADDI / ANDI / ORI / XORI / SUB / SRA
<i>Immediate 1 and 2</i>	These two values compose the 12-bit signed value.

Instruction Format – Jump

U-Type instructions

Control instructions for unconditional and conditional branches.

Load to the upper register part instructions: LUI, AUIPC.



RISC-V instructions

Instructions of the RV32G, grouped by function:

- **Load and store**
- **ALU operations**
- **Branches and Jumps**
- **Floating Point**
- **Miscellaneous**

In the following some of the most used instructions and pseudoinstructions are described.

Load and Store

- **RISC-V processors use a load-store architecture.**
- **The main memory is accessed only through load and store instructions.**

Load – Examples

lw **load word**

`lw x2, 28(x8)` $\# \ x2 \leftarrow \text{MEM}[x8 + 28]$

lb **load in register a signed Byte**

`lb x1, 28(x8)` $\# \ x1 \leftarrow ([\text{MEM}[x8 + 28]]_7)^{24} \ \#\# \ \text{MEM}[x8 + 28]$

lbu **load Byte unsigned**

`lbu x1, 28(x8)` $\# \ x1 \leftarrow 0^{24} \ \#\# \ \text{MEM}[x8 + 28]$

Load – Examples (II)

lw load a word variable named *VAR* in a register

`lw x2, VAR` `#lw` is a pseudoinstruction in this case

Translated as:

```
auipc x2, 0x10000    # auipc → add upper immediate to pc
lw x2, 0(x2)         # x2 ← PC + 0x10000000, VAR effective address
                    # x2 ← MEM[VAR]
```

la load absolute address in a register

`la x5, VECT` `#la` is a pseudoinstruction

Translated as:

```
auipc x5, 0x10000    # x5 ← PC + 0x10000000
addi x5, x5, -23     # x5 ← x5 - 23 (effective address of VECT)
```

Store – Examples

sw **store word**

`sw x2, 28(x8)    # MEM[x8 + 28]  $\leftarrow$  x2` that is a 32-bit register

sb **store the LSB of a register in memory**

`sb x1, 28(x8)    # [MEM[x8 + 28]  $\leftarrow_8$  x1` - saves only the x1 LSB

sh **store the first two LSB of a register in memory**

`sh x1, 28(x8)    # [MEM[x8 + 28]  $\leftarrow_{16}$  x1` - the first 2 LSB

Store – Examples (II)

sw store a register value in a word variable named *VAR*

```
la x2, VAR      #no pseudoinstructions for the store is available
sw x5, 0(x2)
```

Translated as:

```
auipc x2, 0x10000      # x2 ← PC + 0x10000000
addi x2, x2, -48        # x2 ← effective address of VAR
sw x5, 0(x2)           # MEM[VAR] ← x5
```

Load / Store additional examples

Example instruction	Instruction name	Meaning
ld x1,80(x2)	Load doubleword	$\text{Regs}[x1] \leftarrow \text{Mem}[80 + \text{Regs}[x2]]$
lw x1,60(x2)	Load word	$\text{Regs}[x1] \leftarrow_{64} \text{Mem}[60 + \text{Regs}[x2]]_0^{32} \text{###}$ $\text{Mem}[60 + \text{Regs}[x2]]$
lwu x1,60(x2)	Load word unsigned	$\text{Regs}[x1] \leftarrow_{64} 0^{32} \text{###} \text{Mem}[60 + \text{Regs}[x2]]$
lb x1,40(x3)	Load byte	$\text{Regs}[x1] \leftarrow_{64} (\text{Mem}[40 + \text{Regs}[x3]])_0^{56} \text{###}$ $\text{Mem}[40 + \text{Regs}[x3]]$
lbu x1,40(x3)	Load byte unsigned	$\text{Regs}[x1] \leftarrow_{64} 0^{56} \text{###} \text{Mem}[40 + \text{Regs}[x3]]$
lh x1,40(x3)	Load half word	$\text{Regs}[x1] \leftarrow_{64} (\text{Mem}[40 + \text{Regs}[x3]])_0^{48} \text{###}$ $\text{Mem}[40 + \text{Regs}[x3]]$
flw f0,50(x3)	Load FP single	$\text{Regs}[f0] \leftarrow_{64} \text{Mem}[50 + \text{Regs}[x3]] \text{###} 0^{32}$
fld f0,50(x2)	Load FP double	$\text{Regs}[f0] \leftarrow_{64} \text{Mem}[50 + \text{Regs}[x2]]$
sd x2,400(x3)	Store double	$\text{Mem}[400 + \text{Regs}[x3]] \leftarrow_{64} \text{Regs}[x2]$
sw x3,500(x4)	Store word	$\text{Mem}[500 + \text{Regs}[x4]] \leftarrow_{32} \text{Regs}[x3]_{32..63}$
fsw f0,40(x3)	Store FP single	$\text{Mem}[40 + \text{Regs}[x3]] \leftarrow_{32} \text{Regs}[f0]_{0..31}$
fsd f0,40(x3)	Store FP double	$\text{Mem}[40 + \text{Regs}[x3]] \leftarrow_{64} \text{Regs}[f0]$
sh x3,502(x2)	Store half	$\text{Mem}[502 + \text{Regs}[x2]] \leftarrow_{16} \text{Regs}[x3]_{48..63}$
sb x2,41(x3)	Store byte	$\text{Mem}[41 + \text{Regs}[x3]] \leftarrow_8 \text{Regs}[x2]_{56..63}$

ALU operations

All operations are performed on operands held in the processor registers

Instruction types

- **Immediate and three-operand Instructions**
- **Shift instructions**
- **Multiply and divide instructions if M extension is available**

2's complement arithmetic

- **Add**
- **Subtract**
- **Multiply**
- **Divide.**

ALU operations: x0 usage

- **Loading a constant in a register**

addi immediate with x0 as source operand

addi x1, x0, 10 #x1 ← 10

- **Mov register to register**

add x2 and x0 as source operands

add x1, x0, x2 #x1 ← x2

ALU – shift and slt operations

sll shift left logical $x3 \leftarrow x2, x1$ times

`sll x3,x2,x1` $\#x3 \leftarrow x2 \ll x1$

slli shift left logical $x3 \leftarrow x2, \#immediate$ value times

`slli x3,x2,4` $\#x3 \leftarrow x2 \ll 4$

slti set less than immediate

`slti x3,x2,4` $\#IF (x2 < 4) \ x3 \leftarrow 1$
 $\#ELSE \ x3 \leftarrow 0$

ALU – shift and slt operations (II)

seqz **set if $rs = 0$**

`seqz x1,x2`

Translated as:

`sltiu x1, x2, 1` #IF ($x2 == 0$) $x1 \leftarrow 1$
 #ELSE $x1 \leftarrow 0$

snez **set if $rs \neq 0$**

`snez x1,x2`

Translated as:

`sltu x1, x0, x2` #IF ($x2 \neq 0$) $x1 \leftarrow 1$
 #ELSE $x1 \leftarrow 0$

ALU – other examples

lui Load Upper Immediate

It places the U-immediate value in the top 20 bits of the destination register rd, filling in the lowest 12 bits with zeros.

```
lui x1,0x12345        #x1 ← 0x12345 ## 011..0
```

It is possible to build 32-bit constants as:

```
lui x1,0x12345        #x1 ← 0x12345 ## 011..0
```

```
addi x1, x1, 0x678    #x1 ← x1 + 0x678  
                      #x1 ← 0x12345678
```

Branches and Jumps

Control transfer instructions are mainly unconditional jumps and conditional branches.

- **PC-relative jumps**
- **Jump to register**
- **Conditional branches.**

Jump instructions

j label a PC relative jump having a $\pm 1\text{MiB}$ range.

```
j label1
```

Translated as:

```
jal x0, label1            #Jump and link
```

jal label a PC relative jump and link having a $\pm 1\text{MiB}$ range
saves the return value in x1.

```
jal label1
```

Translated as:

```
jal x1, label1
```

Jump instructions (II)

jal x3, label a PC relative jump and link having a $\pm 1\text{MiB}$ range
saves the return value in x3.

```
jal x3, label
```

jr rs1 an indirect jump to register. $\pm 2\text{kiB} + \text{rs1}$ range

```
jr x3
```

Translated as:

```
jalr x0, 0(x3)
```

Jump instructions (III)

jalr rs1 an indirect jump and link to register. $\pm 2\text{kiB} + \text{rs1}$ range
saves the return value in x1.

`jalr x3`

Translated as:

`jalr x1, 0(x3)`

jalr rd, rs, offset an indirect jump and link to register.
saves the return value in rd.

`jalr x3, x2, 0` #jumps to $x2+0$, saves return in x3

Jump instructions (IV)

call sub1 call a subroutine sub1. return address in x1.

`call sub1`

Translated as:

`auipc x1, sub1   # x1 ← sub1 relative addr.`
`jalr x1, offset(x1)`

ret return from a subroutine

`ret`

Translated as:

`jalr x0, 0(x1)`

Branch instructions

B-Type instructions

- Special type for branch instructions with a range of $\pm 4\text{kiB}$ and a 12-bit immediate value.



- The offset must be a multiple of 2.
- Branch instructions compare two registers Rs1 and Rs2

Branch instructions (II)

B-Type instructions

- **BEQ and BNE** take the branch if rs1 and rs2 are equal or unequal.
- **BLT and BLTU** take the branch if rs1 is less than rs2
- **BGE and BGEU** take the branch if rs1 is greater than or equal to rs2
- **BGT, BGTU, BLE, and BLEU** can be synthesized by reversing the operands to BLT, BLTU, BGE, and BGEU.

Branch instructions (II)

B-Type instructions

- **BEQ and BNE** take the branch if rs1 and rs2 are equal or unequal.
 - **BLT and BLTU** take the branch if rs1 is less than rs2
 - **BGE and BGEU** take the branch if rs1 is greater than or equal to rs2
 - **BGT, BGTU, BGE, and BGEU** can be synthesized by reversing the operands to BLT, BLTU, BGE, and BGEU.
- Signed and unsigned comparisons are allowed

Branch instructions – examples

beqz rs, label branch if rs = 0

beqz x3, label

Translated as:

beq x3, x0, label

bnez rs, label branch if rs ≠ 0

bnez x3, label

Translated as:

bne x3, x0, label

Branch instructions – examples (II)

bltz rs, label **branch if rs < 0**

`bltz x3, label`

Translated as:

`blt x3, x0, label`

bgtz rs, label **branch if rs > 0**

`bgtz x3, label`

Translated as:

`blt x0, x3, label`

ISA for the RV64G

- **RV64G instruction set:**
- **This is the 64-bit RISC-V possible ISA defined as RV64IMAFD general-purpose scalar instruction set.**
- **The 32-bit version is called RV32G.**

Instruction type/opcode	Instruction meaning
<i>Data transfers</i>	<i>Move data between registers and memory, or between the integer and FP; only memory address mode is 12-bit displacement+contents of a GPR</i>
lb, lbu, sb	Load byte, load byte unsigned, store byte (to/from integer registers)
lh, lhu, sh	Load half word, load half word unsigned, store half word (to/from integer registers)
lw, lwu, sw	Load word, store word (to/from integer registers)
ld, sd	Load doubleword, store doubleword
<i>Arithmetic/logical</i>	<i>Operations on data in GPRs. Word versions ignore upper 32 bits</i>
add, addi, addw, addiw, sub, subi, subw, subiw	Add and subtract, with both word and immediate versions
slt, sltu, slti, sltiu	set-less-than with signed and unsigned, and immediate
and, or, xor, andi, ori, xori	and, or, xor, both register-register and register-immediate
lui	Load upper immediate: loads bits 31..12 of a register with the immediate value. Upper 32 bits are set to 0
auipc	Sums an immediate and the upper 20-bits of the PC into a register; used for building a branch to any 32-bit address
sll, srl, sra, slli, srli, sraiw, sllw, slliw, srli, srliw, srai, sraiw	Shifts: logical shift left and right and arithmetic shift right, both immediate and word versions (word versions leave the upper 32 bit untouched)
mul, mulw, mulh, mulhsu, mulhu, div, divw, divu, rem, remu, remw, remuw	Integer multiply, divide, and remainder, signed and unsigned with support for 64-bit products in two instructions. Also word versions
<i>Control</i>	<i>Conditional branches and jumps; PC-relative or through register</i>
beq, bne, blt, bge, bltu, bgeu	Branch based on compare of two registers, equal, not equal, less than, greater or equal, signed and unsigned
jal, jalr	Jump and link address relative to a register or the PC
<i>Floating point</i>	<i>All FP operation appear in double precision (.d) and single (.s)</i>
flw, fld, fsw, fsd	Load, store, word (single precision), doubleword (double precision)
fadd, fsub, fmult, fiv, fsqrt, fmadd, fmsub, fnmadd, fnmsub, fmin, fmax, fsgn, fsgnj, fsjnx	Add, subtract, multiply, divide, square root, multiply-add, multiply-subtract, negate multiply-add, negate multiply-subtract, maximum, minimum, and instructions to replace the sign bit. For single precision, the opcode is followed by: .s, for double precision: .d. Thus fadd.s, fadd.d
feq, flt, fle	Compare two floating point registers; result is 0 or 1 stored into a GPR
fmv.x.*, fmv.*.x	Move between the FP register abd GPR, “*” is s or d
fcvt.*.l, fcvt.l.*, fcvt.*.lu, fcvt.lu.*, fcvt.*.w, fcvt.w.*, fcvt.*.wu, fcvt.wu.*	Converts between a FP register and integer register, where “*” is S or D for single or double precision. Signed and unsigned versions and word, doubleword versions

Miscellaneous instructions

nop **No operation instruction**

`addi    x0 , x0 , 0            #nop`